



The modern world

The world today has been shaped by two world wars, huge political changes, and amazing new inventions. People have fought to create many different types of government. The population continues to grow, and exciting new technology is still being developed.

1914–1918

World War I

A war that begins in Europe in 1914 is fought around the world for four years. More than 18 million people are killed.



Gas mask used in WWI

1917

Russia in revolt

Russia gets rid of its tsar (king) and becomes the first communist country, aiming for everyone to be equal.

1939–1945

World War II

The biggest war in human history breaks out in Europe in 1939 and soon spreads around the world. More than 60 million people are killed.

1936–1939

Spanish Civil War

The Spanish Army led by General Franco fights against the elected government, winning power over the whole of Spain in 1939.



WWI fighter plane

1957

Ghana gains independence

The Gold Coast becomes the first black, British-ruled colony in Africa to gain independence, becoming the country of Ghana.



Flag of Ghana

1957

EEC founded

Six European nations form the European Economic Community (EEC), making it easier for them to trade (buy and sell) goods with each other.

1953

Everest is conquered

New Zealander Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay from Nepal become the first people to climb Everest, the world's highest mountain.

1957

Sputnik 1 flies around the world

The USSR launches the first satellite made by humans into space. It takes 96.2 minutes to orbit (travel around) Earth.

1961

JFK becomes US president

At 43, John F. Kennedy becomes the youngest president in US history. He is shot dead in 1963.



John F. Kennedy on a half-dollar coin

1962

Cuban missile crisis

The United States and the USSR almost go to war after the USSR places nuclear missiles on the island of Cuba, close to the United States.

1964–1975

Vietnam War

The United States fights with South Vietnam against communist North Vietnam. In 1975, North Vietnam wins control of all Vietnam.

2016

Britain votes to leave the EU

A member of the EU since 1973, Britain votes to leave the group.



EU Flag

2012

World population above 7 billion

The total population of the world rises above 7 billion for the first time.

2002

The Euro

Twelve members of a group of countries in Europe called the European Union (EU) begin using the same money—the Euro.

2001

9/11

Islamic terrorist group al-Qaeda flies two planes into the Twin Towers in New York City. Almost 3,000 people are killed.



Euro bill and coins